Lab 02: Observational Sketch: Café Object

Level: Foundation Suggested time: 60 minutes Platform: Complete the core brief in either Procreate or Sketchbook Studio; use the comparison notes to transfer the workflow. Alignment: K10 | A1 | LO1

Scenario

A neighbourhood café needs a hand-drawn icon of a ceramic cup and leaf for a seasonal menu.

Your role: Editorial illustrator Required deliverable: A clean observational sketch built from primitives, landmarks and negative space.

Learning goal

Apply Gesture | shape construction | proportion | line weight | reference overlay to a real design decision and produce evidence that meets explicit acceptance criteria.

Before you begin

- Use an iPad that supports your chosen app and a compatible stylus where available.
- Save an editable, layered master before exporting a flattened image.
- Use only owned, licensed or clearly permitted reference images and record their sources.
- Create a folder named Lab-02-<YourName> for working files and evidence.

Part A - Plan and construct

1. Photograph or use an owned image of a ceramic cup with one leaf; record the source in your notes.
2. Write the intended icon qualities: recognisable, warm, hand-made and clean at 64 px.
3. Create a 2000 × 2000 px square canvas and place the reference where it can be hidden.
4. Block an envelope around the cup; mark top, bottom, widest point, handle and leaf attachment.
5. Construct the cup from ellipses, a tapered cylinder and the handle's negative space.
6. Compare two ratios: total height:width and handle height:cup height; correct before detail.
7. Refine one decisive contour layer, vary weight at overlaps, then test the silhouette at thumbnail size.

Part B - Procreate pathway

1. Actions → Add → Insert a photo, then lower reference-layer opacity and lock it.
2. Create a Construction layer and sketch with 6B Pencil or another simple pencil.
3. Use QuickShape for the cup ellipses where helpful, then Edit Shape to correct them.
4. Create a Line layer above construction; lower the construction opacity.
5. Use Selection (Freehand) and Transform (Uniform) for one structural correction before detail.
6. Flip the canvas horizontally from Actions → Canvas to check proportion drift.
7. Hide the reference and construction layers; export the final line icon as transparent PNG if required.

Part C - Sketchbook Studio pathway

1. Import the owned photo as a tracing/reference overlay and lower its opacity.

2. Lock or leave the reference layer untouched; create a new construction layer above it.
3. Use Pencil for primitive construction, then Monoline or Fountain for the clean contour.
4. Use the Ruler for intentional straight segments and freehand for organic curves.
5. Duplicate the clean-line layer before a major proportion correction.
6. Hide the reference layer and check the icon at reduced zoom.
7. Export the finished line icon and retain the layered sketch.

Evidence and acceptance checklist

[ ] Primitive construction remains visible on a separate layer

[ ] Proportion checked using two landmarks

[ ] Final line weight shows overlap

[ ] Reference source recorded

[ ] Layered working file is saved and opens correctly.

[ ] Final export uses a clear filename and matches the intended dimensions.

[ ] At least one in-progress screenshot shows the technique in use.

[ ] Reference sources and design decisions are recorded.

Peer review questions

1. Which proportion error was easiest to miss?
2. Where did negative space reveal drift?
3. Which line deserves the strongest weight and why?

Debrief

Use the Observe → Interpret → Connect → Propose pattern:

1. Observe: State what is visible without praise or blame.
2. Interpret: Explain the likely effect on attention, meaning, emotion or use.
3. Connect: Link the effect to the brief, a design principle or the acceptance criteria.
4. Propose: Name one specific change and how you will check whether it works.

Record one decision you will keep, one change you will test, and one technique you can transfer to the other app.

Troubleshooting

- The line feels wobbly: Zoom out, slow the decision rather than the stroke, use shoulder movement, and increase stabilisation only enough to preserve intent.
- Colour leaks during fill: Close the contour, inspect gaps at 100%, or place colour on a separate layer and clean with the precise eraser.
- The file becomes hard to edit: Name or document layer roles, hide unused experiments, group related stages and duplicate before merging or filtering.
- The image looks muddy: Check value grouping, lower overlay opacity, remove competing texture and restore one clear focal contrast.

- Perspective feels wrong: Return to horizon and vanishing logic; correct the large box before windows, props or decoration.

Submission package

Submit Lab-02-<YourName>/ containing:

- layered working file (or the app's saved layered sketch);
- final PNG/JPEG/PDF as required by the brief;
- progress evidence/contact sheet;
- short design rationale answering the peer-review questions; and
- reference/provenance list.

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